She's in Boots, with Ruby. She's stunned, angry, immediately full of all the injustices that had not occurred to me sitting there. She seems more incensed for having to receive the news in Boots. All the Christmases we've missed, all the girls' birthdays I have missed because of a commitment to the England cricket team, all that sacrifice and the first thing that she can think is that she has to hear it's all over while she's in Boots. She knows how grief can merge with the everyday, the sheer disorientation of it. In 2006, she had watched me spend six months out with a stress fracture of my back, unable to move, persuading me that I would be able to play cricket again. We'd got through that, worked it out, weighed up all options and chosen sacrifice again. She couldn't believe that nearly 20 years later it would be put to bed like this.

When I get to Old Trafford, I realise we have tickets in the Manchester United end. Brilliant. Fucking brilliant. I'm there for 90 minutes, head down, pretending not to support Burnley, working out what it will mean not to play cricket for England. When the crowd have dispersed and the outer web of friends in the bar have gone, I tell Gaz and Dave – two of my closest friends – that I think it might be over. The words fall out of my mouth, like I'm trying them out for size for the very first time. Gaz and Dave just stare, shocked, expressions of concern reflected back at me. The world is upside down. It's there that I suddenly realise, soon I will never hear that question again. The one that has chased me around for more than ten years. Sometimes I wonder whether anyone else on earth has been asked a question as many times. My least favourite part of any social interaction. The one that came with every passing stranger or interview or end of a dinner or drink. I hated that question. It's finally here. The R word.

When are you going to retire?

Now I'd trade in anything for another ten years of hearing this question.

You'll know, they all said. You'll just *know*. I read it. I was told it. I even saw it happen, year on year, decade on decade, in front of my own eyes, with each of my teammates. I've had 109 of them. They all had that moment, that feeling, and left the England dressing room one by one; some sad, some relieved, some broken in body, some broken in spirit, all grateful, none unscathed. I waited and waited to know too. At times, I wished for the same brutal epiphany that landed in their laps, just to make my own peace with it. They all knew and, in their own way, accepted that part of their lives